



IN MOST OF PATNA, ALMOST ANY OPEN SPACE IS GOOD ENOUGH FOR A DRINK

drunkards disturb the law and order situation in the neighbourhood. Last year, a group of alcoholics even attacked a deputy superintendent of police, Dilip Jha, in Patna when the officer asked them not to consume liquor in the open. There are other instances as well when the police had to arrest shop owners and tipplers for disturbing the peace close to an educational institution.

Though various citizens' groups have vehemently opposed this new policy, the state Excise Department that was earlier indifferent, has now been forced to reconsider some steps, following the Patna High Court's recent order whereby it directed relocation of an 'ON' liquor shop in Patna's Srikrishna Puri area after residents objected to its continuance. Such shops are a nuisance as they serve as roadside bar of sorts where people can drink in the open.

The high court passed the order following a report of a lawyers' committee that noted that the residents were against the continuance of liquor shops in their locality. "The high court has also agreed to look further into the matter. It has directed the state Government to obtain reports from district magistrates whether the excise rules were being followed in letter and spirit. The Government has to file a counter affidavit in this regard," says senior advocate SBK Mangalam.

The high court acted on a Public Interest Litigation that was initially a complaint filed by seven housewives from Patna—Asha Lal, Madhuri Devi, Rajni Kesari, Manjula Srivastava, Kiran Narayan, Sudha Sinha and Sunita Devi—objecting to the location of an 'ON' liquor shop in their neighbourhood and approached the court in July 2009. Mangalam, who represented the petitioner's, quotes various Excise Act rules to claim that state authorities too have openly violated many statutory provisions of the excise rules while granting licences to liquor shops in the state. "The high



## THE EXCISE POLICY UNVEILED BY THE NITISH KUMAR GOVERNMENT IN 2007 HAS DOUBLED THE NUMBER OF LIQUOR SHOPS AND TRIPLED REVENUES.

operating from almost all neighbourhoods and men sitting on the roads, drinking at shops and even at workplaces, eateries, almost anywhere; they are keeping their date with Bacchus and guzzling away with gusto at the expense of others. In an apparent zeal for maximising profit,

the Government has even allowed these shops close to religious and educational institutions, and also in residential localities. The liberal liquor policy has not only made alcohol easily available and encouraged sales, but has also created social problems in plenty. High on alcohol,